

Session 4: A Tale of Two Journeys

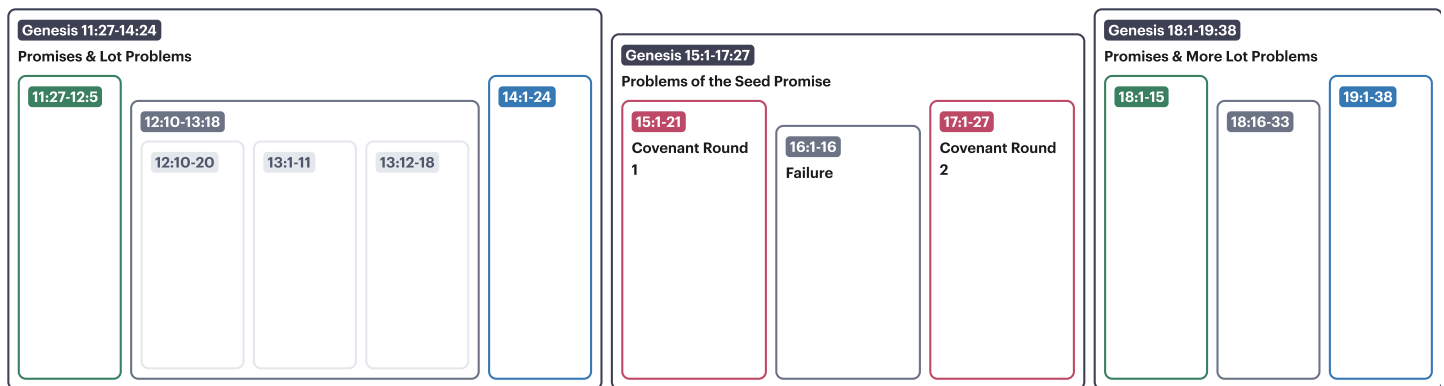
Key Takeaways

- The two stories of Terakh (Terah) and Avram are set alongside each other to compare and contrast: Terakh is marked by death and Avram is marked by blessing.
- Avram is depicted as a new Noah. He leaves the fire oven of Babylon after the scattering, like Noah left the ark after the flood.
- When God calls Avram, the focus of the biblical story narrows from the drama of God and the nations to God's work through one family.

Movement I: From Babylon to Hebron and Sodom (11:27-19:38)

There are three sections in this macro-unit, and they display a tight cohesion and symmetrical design.

The Macro Design of Genesis 11:27-19:38



Genesis 11:27-19:38 (Simplified). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This first large stretch of the Avraham story has been organized into three movements that each consist of three literary units. These triads are symmetrically designed at each level, inviting the reader to make vital comparisons and contrasts that inform each scene's contribution to the whole.

11:27-14:24 and 18:1-19:38

These are two large blocks where Avraham's nephew Lot features as a main character. In both cases, Avraham's disregard for God's command to leave his family behind results in huge trouble, first in Lot's capture by the Babylonian alliance ([Gen. 14](#)), and second when he needs to be rescued from Sodom ([Gen. 19](#)). In both stories God delivers the non-chosen nephew through Avraham's status as the chosen, blessed, and righteous intercessor.

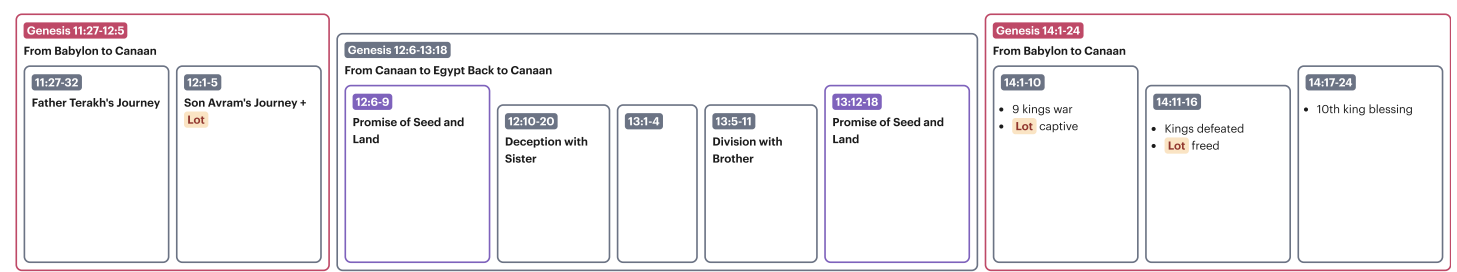
The first promises of a large family for Avraham and Sarah are made in 12:1-9, but they are not fulfilled until 18:1-15.

15:1-17:27

This triad of tightly organized stories is connected in important ways. They all revolve around Avraham's struggle to trust God's promise that he and Sarah will produce a child.

In chapters 15 and 17, Avraham both believes and doesn't believe in God's promise, leading to the second major covenant in the biblical story.

Part 1: The Macro Design of Genesis 11:27-14:24



Genesis 11:27-14:24. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

In this first large movement of the Avraham story, the literary units are determined by movements to and from locations (Babylon, Canaan, and Egypt) and by the main characters in focus.

Notice the symmetrical design of the locations.

Genesis 11:27-12:5

From Babylon to Canaan

- Avram brings Lot (a no-no!)

Genesis 12:6-7

Canaan: Oak of Moreh

- Divine Revelation: "To your seed I give this land"

Genesis 12:8-9

Between Bethel and Ai to the Negev

- Altar built for worship

Genesis 12:10-20

Egypt

Genesis 13:1-11

To the Negev, to between Bethel and Ai

- Altar built for worship

Genesis 13:12-28

Canaan: Oaks of Mamre

- Divine revelation: "all the land ... I give to you and your seed"

Genesis 14:

Babylonian Invasion of Canaan

- Lot's presence brings trouble upon Avram

Genesis 11:27-14:24. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This design encourages the reader to compare the two stories that feature Babylon and the presence of Lot in Avram's family. In chapters 11-12, Avram brings Lot even though God told him to leave his family behind. This decision comes to haunt Avram in the story of the dispute between Lot and Avram that leads to his migration to Sodom. And, of course, Lot's presence in Sodom causes huge headaches for Avram in chapter 14.

Nested inside of the Babylon/Lot stories are two stories where Avram builds altars by sacred trees and receives a divine revelation about his future inheritance of the land. In the first story, it's a gift from God. In the second story at Mamre (13:12-18), the gift of the land reverses the danger Avram and Lot's dispute posed to the promise.

Inside of that are two stories about Avraham meeting God's presence in the land and building altars for worship; he is staking out the land as a place of sacred worship.

At the very center of this sequence is Avram's self-imposed exile in Egypt that leads to disaster when he puts the future of the promised seed in jeopardy.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 11:27-12:5

Introduction

²⁷ Now these are the generations of Terakh.

Part 1: Terakh's Journey

Death and Barrenness in Ur-Kasdim

- a **Terakh** caused the birth of **Avram**, **Nakhor** and **Haran** ;
a' and Haran caused the birth of **Lot** .
b 28 And **Haran died before his father Terakh**
c in **the land of his family**,
c in **Ur of the Chaldeans** .
-
- a 29 And **Avram** and **Nakhor** took wives for themselves,
b **the name of Avram's wife was Sarai** ;
c and **the name of Nakhor's wife was Milkah**,
c' the **daughter of Haran**, the father of **Milkah** and Iskah.
b' 30 **And Sarai was barren, she had no child** .

Terakh Takes His Family

- 31 **And Terakh took** (ויקה תרח...) **Avram** his son
and Lot , the son of Haran, the son of his son,
and Sarai his daughter-in-law, his son Avram's wife;

They Go Out of Ur To Enter Canaan but Don't Reach It

- and they went out** with them from **Ur of the Chaldeans**
in order to go to the land of Canaan ;
and they went as far as Haran, and they settled there.

Terakh Age + Death in Haran

- 32 And **the days of Terakh were five years and two hundred years**;
and Terakh died in Haran .

Part 2: Avram's Journey

Blessing and Children in the Promised Land

- 12:1 And Yahweh said to Avram,
a "Get yourself going
b **from your land**,
b' and **from your family**,
b' and **from your father's house** ,
a' to the land which I will show you.

- a 2 **And I will make you a great nation**,
- b and I will bless you,
- a' and I will make your name great;
- b' and so you shall be a blessing.
- a 3 And I will **bless**
- b **those who** **bless** you,
- b' and **the one who** treats you as **cursed**
- a' I will **curse**;
- a and in you all the **families of the land**
- b will find blessing."

Avram's Age + Exit From Haran

4 And Avram went just as Yahweh spoke to him, and Lot went with him, and **Avram was five and seventy years** **when he went out from Haran**.

Avram Takes His Family

5 **And Avram took (...ויקח אברם)**
Sarai his wife and Lot the son of his brother
 and all their possessions which they possessed
 and the people whom they had acquired in Haran,

They Go Out of Haran To Enter Canaan and Do Reach It

and they went out
in order to go to the land of Canaan
and they went the land of Canaan.

Genesis 11:27-12:5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Maps of Terakh's and Avram's Journeys



[Openstreetmap.org](https://www.openstreetmap.org).

Notice how this two-step journey is also a two-generation journey. What Terakh begins, Avram completes, but only because of the word of God that comes to Avram.

Terakh's journey begins with two tragic notes: Haran's death and the barrenness of Sarai his daughter-in-law. Sarai's infertility also highlights the contrast between her and her sister-in-law Milkah. They both have royal names ("Princess" and "Queen"), but Milkah's identity is described in terms of her family relations, while Sarai's identity is described only in relation to her inability to have children.

Terakh's journey begins with these tragic notes and then issues in a three-stage process from (1) "taking," to (2) "going out," and then (3) arriving in Haran where Terakh dies. Terakh's journey begins with Haran's death and ends with his own death in another Haran.



[Openstreetmap.org](https://www.openstreetmap.org).

Avram's journey begins with a recall to the two tragic notes that began Terakh's journey. He is to leave his family and father's house (marked by death), and God will make him a great nation (thus reversing Sarai's infertility).

Not only will God reverse the tragedies of his family, but he will bring about a Genesis 1 blessing that will produce an overabundance of blessing that will flow out from him to the other families of the nations.

Once Avram has received this divine word of blessing that reverses his father’s fate, he begins his own three-step process of (1) “taking,” (2) “going out,” and (3) arriving in Canaan.

When he finally arrives in Canaan, Avram completes the journey his father began. Notice how the scenes alternate precisely between three journey stages, punctuated by two stops in Shechem and Bethel where Avram builds altars and worships Yahweh, who called him and his family out of Ur of the Chaldeans.

A New Noah, A New Adam

The literary design of [Genesis 6:1-11:26](#) prepares us to see Avram’s exit from Ur of the Chaldeans after the scattering of Babylon in [11:27-12:9](#) as parallel to Noah’s exit from the ark after the flood.

Noah’s Exit From the Ark and Family Blessing	Avram’s Exit From Babylon and Family Blessing
Ten generations from Adam to Noah; 3 sons	Ten generations from Noah to Avram (of 3 sons)
Gen. 6:1-4 The flood story begins with violence and bloodshed perpetrated by warriors and “men of the name ”	Gen. 10:8-12 Babylon is founded by a violent warrior, a man of the name Gen. 11:1-9 Babylon is built by people who seek to make a name for themselves
Noah and those with him are sheltered in the ark during the flood	Terakh and those with him take refuge in Haran after the scattering of Babylon
Noah “goes out” from the ark with his family (צא repeated 4x in Gen. 8:16-19): “and Noah went out from the ark, and his sons and his wife and his sons’ wives”	Gen. 11:31 Terakh “went out” from Babylon with his family: “and Terakh took Avram his son ... and they went out with them from Ur of Chaldeans” Gen. 12:5 Avram “went out” from Haran with his family “and Avram took his wife and the son of his brothers ... and they went out to go to the land of Canaan ”
God promises that Noah and his wife will be “fruitful and multiply” Gen. 9:1 “And God blessed them and said, ‘Be fruitful and multiply and fill the land’”	God promises to make Avram and his wife “fruitful and multiply” Gen. 12:1-2 “And Yahweh said to Avram, ‘... I will make you a great nation and I will bless you ...’”
Exiting the Ark and Babylon. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Just as Noah’s life was preserved amidst a great act of divine judgment on human violence, so Terakh’s family is preserved from the divine judgment-scattering of Babylon. Noah’s exit from the divinely provided shelter is

followed by a promise of fruitfulness and blessing, and Avram’s exit from Haran includes a divine call to go to a new land of fruitfulness and blessing. All of these similarities highlight one of the major contrasts between Noah and Avram: Sarai’s inability to have children is very different from Noah and his wife’s many children and grandchildren. This contrast prepares us for the great drama of the Avram and Sarai story.

A Tale of Two Sojourns: Babylon and the Chosen Line

The sojourn of Terakh and Avraham is contrasted with the sojourn in the previous narrative of Noah’s sons that ends in the rebellion and scattering of Babylon. One story ends with disaster and the other begins in blessing.

Genesis 11:1-9 A Sojourn Into Disaster	Genesis 11:27-12:9 A Sojourn Into Blessing
Begins with “all the land ... journeying (נסע) from the east (מקדם)” [11:1-2] Concludes with “all the land” being “scattered” (נפוץ / הפיץ) [11:9]	Begins with one family leaving (ויצאו) the place of scattering, Ur of Chasdim [11:31] Concludes with Avram “journeying” (נסע) into Canaan in places “from the east” (מקדם) [12:8-9]
They find a “plain in Shinar” and “they settled there” (וישבו שם) [11:2]	They come to Haran and “they settled there” (וישבו שם) [11:31]
“Let us build (בנה) for ourselves a city and tower” [11:4] “... the city and tower which the sons of ‘adam built (בנה) for themselves” [11:5]	“and Yahweh said” (ויאמר יהוה) [12:1] followed by a reversal of circumstances — from barrenness to birth
“Let us make a name (שם) for ourselves” [11:4]	“I will make great your name (שם) [12:2]
“and Yahweh said” (ויאמר יהוה) [11:6] followed by a reversal of circumstances — from building to scattering	“and [Avram] built (בנה) there an altar to Yahweh” [12:7] “and [Avram] built (בנה) there an altar to Yahweh and he called upon the name (שם) of Yahweh.” [12:8]
A westward sojourn that ends with settlement by humans who use their potential for their own name, so that Yahweh becomes the antagonist and reverses their circumstances	A westward sojourn that ends with settlement by humans who have no potential to make a name for themselves, so that Yahweh becomes the protagonist and reverses their circumstances
<i>Tale of Two Sojourns. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>	

Notice how the sojourn of “all the land” in [Genesis 6:1-11:26](#) furthers the thematic portrait of human nature expressed in [Genesis 6:5](#) and [8:21](#), “humans are bad from their youth.” They take their God-given potential and unity and use it for selfish and (what will become) imperial ends: the deification and exaltation of their name.

In contrast, the sojourn of Terakh begins with the tragic death of Haran his son, and it ends with his own death in Haran. These deaths are paralleled with Avram and Sarai’s inability to have children and perpetuate their name. But God intervenes with a word of promise and blessing, motivating one final sojourn westward to the land of Canaan.

Note how sojourning and building are at the center of both narratives, but toward opposite ends. The Babylonians build a city and tower for their own name, while Avram builds altars for Yahweh’s name.

From Where Was Avram Called?

The two narratives of [Genesis 11:27-32](#) and [12:1-9](#) contrast the journeys of Terakh and Avram. The first says that it was Terakh who “went out from Ur of the Chaldeans” to journey to Canaan, but instead he only made it to Haran and settled there ([11:31](#)). In contrast, Avram is addressed by God to go to Canaan, and so he “goes out” from an unidentified location ([12:5](#)) to go to Canaan. From where does Avram go to Canaan, and where is the location of God’s first appearance and speech to him in [12:1-5](#)?

Option 1: In Haran

The literary sequence of the two narrative units ([11:27-32](#) and [12:1-9](#)) could be interpreted as a time sequence where Avram’s journey with his father to Haran preceded God’s speech to him to leave and go to Canaan.

There is a wrinkle in this straightforward interpretation, however. The only other time Avram’s journey to Canaan is referenced in the Hebrew Bible, he is said to have been summoned by God to leave Ur of the Chaldeans, not Haran.

Genesis 15:7 NASB*
And he said to him, “I am Yahweh who **brought you out of Ur of the Chaldeans**, to give you this land to possess it.”
*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Option 2: In Ur of the Chaldeans

The literary sequence of [Genesis 11:27-32](#) and [12:1-5](#) does not necessarily indicate the sequence of events referenced by the narrative. It is not uncommon in biblical narrative for two consecutive narrative units to be placed out of chronological order so that the author can achieve the literary effect of juxtaposition, forcing the reader to compare and contrast the two versions of similar events. This has already happened at key junctures in Genesis 1-11.

Example 1	Gen. 1:1-2:3 Creation of the ordered land out of the dark waters	Gen. 2:4-17 Creation of the fruitful garden out of the barren wilderness
Example 2	Gen. 10:1-32 • Babylon built by Nimrod as he spreads	Gen. 11:1-9 • Babylon built a “name-seeking”

Narrative Versus Event Sequence. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

his empire
• Nations already scattered with many languages

humanity
• Nations not yet scattered and only one language

Narrative Versus Event Sequence. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

In both cases, the literary sequence does not correspond to the event sequence. Rather, it allows the author to portray the same event from two angles, highlighting different themes and ideas as they render the same core event. The same technique is used in the presentation of Terakh's and Avram's journey from Ur to Canaan. And there is another textual clue that makes it clear this is the case.

The Ages of Avram and Terakh

The narrator makes clear that Terakh had his three sons at the age of 70 and then died at the age of 205. Avram, we're told, was 75 when he received God's calling to leave his family and go to Canaan.

Genesis 11:26 NASB*

Terakh lived seventy years, and became the father of Avram, Nakhor, and Haran.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 11:31-32 NASB*

³¹ Terakh took Avram his son, and Lot the son of Haran, his grandson, and Sarai his daughter-in-law, his son Avram's wife; and they went out together from Ur of the Chaldeans in order to enter the land of Canaan; and they went as far as Haran, and settled there. ³² **The days of Terakh were two hundred and five years; and Terakh died in Haran.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 12:4-5 NASB*

⁴ So Avram went forth as Yahweh had spoken to him; and Lot went with him. **Now Avram was seventy-five years old when he departed from Haran.** ⁵ ... thus they came to the land of Canaan.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The implication of these numbers is very clear. Terakh had his sons at age 70, and his son Avram left for Canaan at age 75. This means that Terakh was still alive at 145 years old when Avram was summoned by God in 12:1. Even though Terakh's death is recorded in 11:32, before Avram leaves for Canaan, the ages given by the narrator show that Terakh is still alive when Avram, Sarai, and Lot leave him.

"Biblical protagonists frequently exit the narrative stage long before their chronological lives are over. For example, Noah dies before the Abraham narrative begins. But a simple calculation shows that Noah dies when Abraham was 58 years old (see Gen. 9:28-29); similarly Isaac was still alive when his grandson Joseph was sold (Gen. 35:28-29). Genesis ... is a sweeping series of portraits that trace a character from birth to death before the next character is introduced ... The spotlight only falls on Abram once Terah has stepped down, despite the fact that the first events in the Abram story occur during Terah's lifetime ... This narrative

style illuminates the correlation between Terah's journey and God's revelation to Abram ... It is reasonable to conclude that Terah's decision to immigrate to Canaan is connected to God's command to Abram." Grossman, Jonathan (2016). [*Abram to Abraham: A Literary Analysis of the Abraham Narrative*](#). Peter Lang. 74-75.

Conclusion

The narrator has separated the single departure of Terakh and Avram from Ur of the Chaldeans into two distinct narrative portraits to highlight the different meanings of their journeys.

Terakh's journey is associated with death and infertility.

Genesis 11:28 NASB

Haran died in the presence of his father Terah in the land of his birth, in Ur of the Chaldeans.

Genesis 11:30 NASB*

Sarai was **infertile**; she had no child.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 11:32 NASB*

... and Terakh **died** in Haran.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In contrast, Avram's journey, which was the same as his father's, is associated with obedience to God's calling, followed by blessing and the promise of family and abundance.

Genesis 12:1-2 Instructor's Translation

¹ ... Go from your land and from your family ... to the land I will show you. ² ... and **I will make you and great nation** and **I will bless you**.

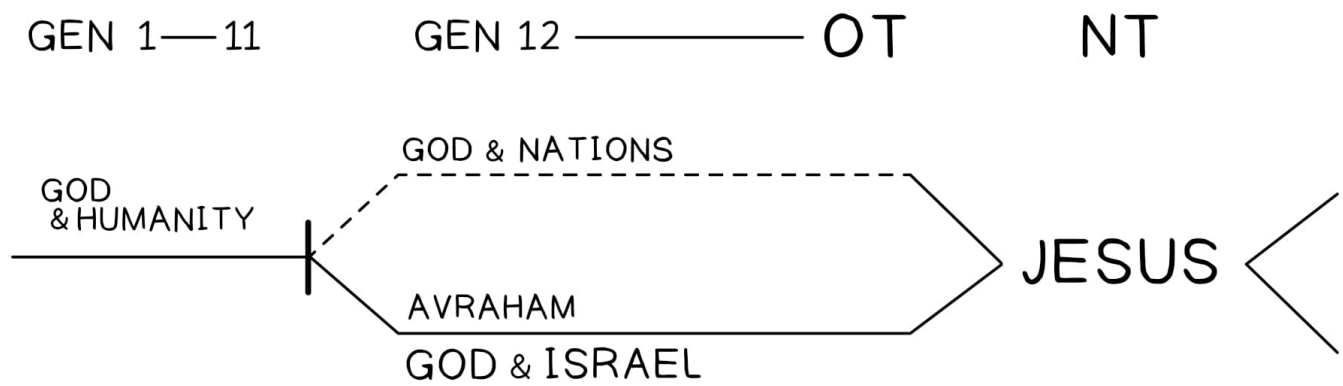
Genesis 12:4 Instructor's Translation

And Avram went just as Yahweh spoke to him ...

Genesis 12:7 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh said to Avram, "**To your seed I will give this land.**"

Narrative Focus of the Hebrew Bible



Narrative Focus of the Hebrew Bible. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

What is the turning point in the story of the journey from Ur to Canaan? How does this recall earlier themes in Genesis?